



MARKETING LABS · CUSTOMERS & LOYALTY

The Hook Model

Design return behaviour around meaningful value.

Interactive Hook Model canvas for ethical habit-forming product design.

Includes: framework reference · guidance by Hook stage · printable worksheet

The Hook Model: reference

INTERACTIVE PRODUCT-BEHAVIOUR PROTOTYPE

Map the four parts of a repeat-use loop: what prompts a user, the easiest useful action, the value they receive and the contribution that makes the product more valuable next time. Use the model to reduce friction and support beneficial habits—not to exploit attention, anxiety or vulnerability.

Habit-forming is not automatically user-centred. Keep the user's long-term interest as the design constraint. Avoid dark patterns, deceptive urgency, excessive notifications, unwanted data extraction and reward systems that encourage harmful or compulsive use.

Your ethical Hook Model

Select a stage to inspect its design choice, user benefit, evidence and safety guardrail.

GUARDRAILS MAPPED

User wellbeing check

Prompt

Low-friction behaviour

Meaningful payoff

Future value

REPEAT VALUE LOOP

Each stage should help a user achieve a worthwhile outcome with informed, controllable participation.

LOOP COMPLETENESS

All four stages are mapped. Check that every stage delivers a legitimate user benefit and does not depend on harmful pressure.

VALUE TEST

Ask a value question: would a well-informed user say this loop helps them accomplish something they genuinely want, in a way they would choose again?

CONTROL TEST

All stages include evidence or guardrails. Validate these safeguards through accessibility review, user research and product analytics—not assumptions.

Ethical design checks

- Does the product solve a real, user-defined problem rather than create anxiety or dependence to generate engagement?
- Can people control prompts, reminders, personalisation, notifications and recommendations without penalty?
- Is the desired action understandable, reversible where possible and free from deceptive defaults or hidden costs?
- Does the reward provide genuine value without gambling-like uncertainty, fear of missing out or harmful social comparison?
- Is every investment voluntary, proportionate and transparent—and can users export or delete their data easily?

- Would you be comfortable explaining the loop, its data use and its likely effects to users, regulators and an independent ethics reviewer?

Guidance by Hook stage

Trigger

Action

Variable Reward

Investment

The Hook Model: your canvas

Print this page or fill it in by hand. The interactive lab asks the same questions.

Product, service or experience

For example: A learning app, SaaS product or subscription service

Hook stage

☐ Trigger ☐ Action ☐ Variable Reward ☐ Investment

Design decision

Describe the user experience, not merely the feature.

User benefit

What legitimate problem does this solve or outcome does it support?

Evidence and ethical guardrail

How will you know it works, and what limit protects the user?

Planning aid, not advice. Test assumptions with evidence and consider privacy, accessibility, fairness and sustainability before acting.